2. Browse to the source (for our example, the *qgis_sample_data/shapefiles* directory).
3. Select the files (in our case, *alaska.shp* and *airports.shp*). Figure 1 shows the Map Canvas with the Alaska and Airports layers.

Layer styles

Styling allows us to set fill colours, patterns, borders, icons, etc, for the features in the layer:

1. Right click the Airport layer in the *Layers* panel and select *Properties.*
2. Under the *Style* tab you can change the symbol and colour, the size of the symbol, set transparency, and categorise the features (see Figure 2).

Layer labels

Labels are text identifiers for features in the layer. QGIS allows you to choose the attribute you want to show as the label, and set its style too (see Figure 3):

1. Right click the Airport layer and select *Properties*.
2. Under the *Labels* tab, check mark *Display Labels*.
3. Select the *Field Containing Label*; this is the text to be shown on the layer.
4. Set the font size, colour, type, and the text position with respect to the feature location.

Attributes table

Attributes describe the features in a layer. The attribute values can be edited and queried. To view attribute names and data, right click the Airport layer and choose *Open Attribute Table.*

To query features of your interest, add the text to filter the data in the *Look For* text box, and select the desired field. For instance: look for 'Military' in the field 'Cat'. Then hit *Search*. You will find that all military airports are selected and highlighted in the Attribute Table, as in Figure 4, and on the map. For complex queries, try *Advanced Search.*

Selected features can be saved as a new shapefile: click *Layer > Save Selection as vector file*. Select the format as *ESRI Shapefile* and save.

In Part II, we will learn how to publish a map, plot custom data and perform geoprocessing. END

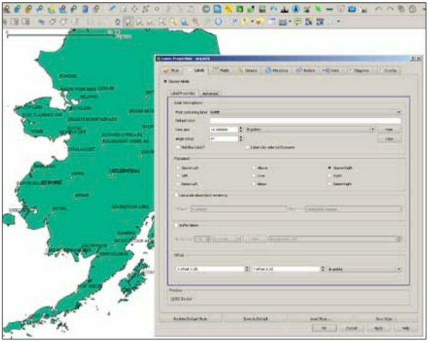

Figure 3: Feature labels

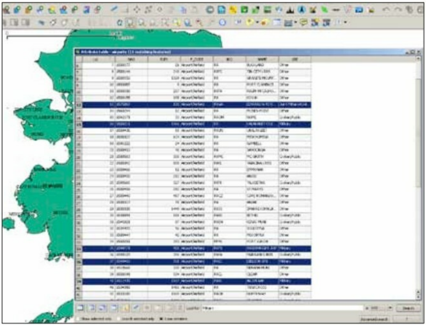

Figure 4: Feature selection

By: Sagar Arlekar & Niket Narang

The authors are researchers at the Center for Study of Science, Technology and Policy (CSTEP), Bengalore. They work in the fields of GIS and Agent-Based Simulation. At CSTEP they have built a web-based GIS framework to simulate and visualize disaster impact. They love working with open source tools and are active contributors to Openstreetmaps.